Rural Employment Guarantee Act, who my Tamil Nadu Mahila Congress team had brought together. Despite the Act being a demand-driven scheme, they complained that they could not avail of the work or get unemployment benefits. At the end of the interaction, one of the older women started insisting that Rahul ji get married to someone from Kanyakumari so he could become Tamil Nadu's son-in-law. After such an intense and serious discussion, this sparked general hilarity from everyone. But Rahul ji was humble, involved and magnanimous, like in every instance. And to be so kind and patient when he himself had tremendous pain in his knee … How could anyone possibly say (as the Sangh does) that he was a princeling who didn't care? Every single day I saw him, I just kept thinking that he was the best possible leader for India.

The Essence of Bharat Jodo Yatra

One of the macro-level things that I feel the Bharat Jodo Yatra did was transform passive spectators into engaged citizens. Many people had clearly come just to see Rahul Gandhi and this grand serpentine rally floating through their villages and towns. But seeing us limping, smiling and talking to them made them want to join us. They started joining us and feeding us. Children played with us, girls shyly hugged us and the elderly chatted with us. I think we were changing minds as we went along. This was happening in all of the twelve states, across cultures, regions and language divides. This whole experience suggested that politics demands participation rather than mere observation.

Secondly, I made some fantastic friends during the Yatra. Politics is very cut-throat, and people might have different motives and agendas. But in the Yatra, barriers and ceilings were broken daily. My container mate Ruchira became like my sister; Apeksha, Dinesh, Mohan, Pratishta, Pushparaj and others became my close friends, as did many others. The bonds we formed have outlasted the Yatra. But even more importantly, I saw that 90 per cent of people in the Yatra (yatris and organizers) were good people who were in